

Unidentified Traffic Sighting
by Japan Airlines Flight 1628
November 18, 1986
ANC ARTCC

DRAFT

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U.S. Department
of Transportation
**Federal Aviation
Administration**

Memorandum

Anchorage ARTCC
5400 Davis Hwy.
Anchorage, Alaska

Subject: INFORMATION: Transcription concerning the Date: January 9, 1987
incident involving Japan Airlines Flight 1628
on November 18, 1986 at approximately 0218 UTC.

From: Quentin J. Gates Reply to
Air Traffic Manager, Attn. of:
ANC ARTCC

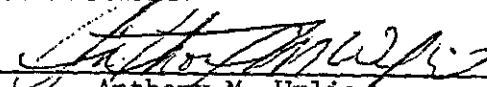
To: This transcription covers the time period from November 18, 1986, 0214 UTC to
November 18, 1986, 0259 UTC.

Agencies Making Transmissions

Abbreviations

Japan Airlines Flight 1628	JL1628
Anchorage ARTCC Combined Sector R/D15	R/D15
Anchorage ARTCC Sector D15	D15
Anchorage ARTCC Sector R15	R15
Regional Operations Command Center	ROCC
United Airlines Flight 69	UA69
TOTEM71	TOTEM
Fairbanks Approach Control	APCH

I hereby certify that the following is a true transcription of the recorded conversations pertaining to the subject incident:


Anthony M. Wylie
Quality Assurance Specialist
Anchorage ARTCC

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U.S. Department
of Transportation
Federal Aviation
Administration

Memorandum

Subject: INFORMATION: Unidentified Traffic Sighting
by Japan Airlines

Date: DEC 18 1986

From: Air Traffic Manager, Anchorage ARTCC, ZAN-1

Reply to
Attn. of:

To: Manager, Air Traffic Division, AAL-500
ATTN: Evaluation Specialist, AAL-514

The attached chronology summarizes the communications and actions of Japan Airlines Flight 1628 on November 18, 1986.

Radar data recorded by Anchorage Center does not confirm the presence of the traffic reported by Flight 1628. No further information has been received from civil or military sources since the date of the sightings.

Major Johnson of the Elmendorf Regional Operations Command Center (ROCC) is checking their records and the operations personnel for further details. He will forward any additional information to Anchorage Center as soon as possible.

Should you have any questions or need additional information, contact Tony Wylie, Quality Assurance Specialist, 269-1162.

Original signed by

Quentin J. Gates

Attachment

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The following is a chronological summary of the alleged aircraft sightings by Japan Airlines Flight 1628, on November 18, 1986:

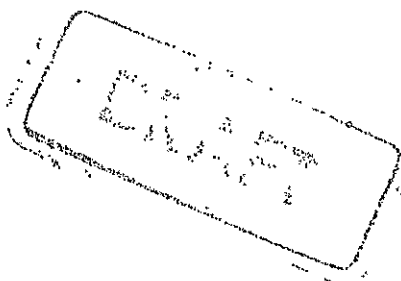
All times listed are approximate UTC unless otherwise specified.

- 0219 - The pilot of JLL1628 requested traffic information from the ZAN Sector 15 controller. When the controller advised there was no traffic in the vicinity, JLL1628 responded that they had same direction traffic, approximately 1 mile in front, and it appeared to be at their altitude. When queried about any identifiable markings, the pilot responded that they could only see white and yellow strobes.
- 0225 - JLL1628 informed ZAN that the traffic was now visible on their radar, in their 11 o'clock position at 8 miles.
- 0226 - ZAN contacted the Military Regional Operations Control Center, (ROCC), and asked if they were receiving any radar returns near the position of JLL1628. The ROCC advised that they were receiving a primary radar return in JLL1628's 10 o'clock position at 8 miles.
- 0227 - The ROCC contacted ZAN to advise they were no longer receiving any radar returns in the vicinity of JLL1628.
- 0231 - JLL1628 advised that the "plane" was "quite big", at which time the ZAN controller approved any course deviations needed to avoid the traffic.
- 0232 - JLL1628 requested and received a descent from FL350 to FL310. When asked if the traffic was descending also, the pilot stated it was descending "in formation".
- 0235 - JLL1628 requested and received a heading change to two one zero. The aircraft was now in the vicinity of Fairbanks and ZAN contacted Fairbanks Approach Control asking if they had any radar returns near JLL1628's position. The Fairbanks Controller advised they did not.
- 0236 - JLL1628 was issued a 360 degree turn and asked to inform ZAN if the traffic stayed with them.
- 0238 - The ROCC called ZAN advising they had confirmed a "flight of two" in JLL1628's position. They advised they had some "other equipment watching this", and one was a primary target only.
- 0239 - JLL1628 told ZAN they no longer had the traffic in sight.
- 0242 - The ROCC advised it looked as though the traffic had dropped back and to the right of JLL1628, however, they were no longer tracking it.
- 0244 - JLL1628 advised the traffic was now at 9 o'clock
- 0245 - ZAN issued a 10 degree turn to a northbound United Airlines flight, after pilot concurrence, in an attempt to confirm the traffic.
- 0248 - JLL1628 told ZAN the traffic was now at 7 o'clock, 8 miles.

0250 - The northbound United Flight advised they had the Japan Airlines flight in sight, against a light background, and could not see any other traffic.

0253 - JL1628 advised they no longer had contact with the traffic.

A subsequent review of ANC ARTCC's radar tracking data failed to confirm any targets in close proximity to JL1628.



PERSONNEL STATEMENT

FEDERAL AVIATION ADMINISTRATION

Anchorage Air Route Traffic Control Center

The following is a report concerning the incident to aircraft JL1628 on November 18, 1986 at 0230 UTC.

My name is Carl E. Henley (HC) I am employed as an Air Traffic Control Specialist by the Federal Aviation Administration at the Anchorage Air Route Traffic Control Center, Anchorage, Alaska.

During the period of 2030 UTC, November 17, 1986, to 0430 UTC, November 18, 1986 I was on duty in the Anchorage ARTCC. I was working the D15 position from 0156 UTC, November 18, 1986 to 0230 UTC, November 18, 1986.

At approximately 0225Z while monitoring JL1628 on Sector 15 radar, the aircraft requested traffic information. I advised no traffic in his vicinity. The aircraft advised he had traffic 12 o'clock same altitude. I asked JL1628 if he would like higher/lower altitude and the pilot replied, negative. I checked with ROCC to see if they had military traffic in the area and to see if they had primary targets in the area. ROCC did have primary target in the same position JL1628 reported. Several times I had single primary returns where JL1628 reported traffic. JL1628 later requested a turn to heading 210°, I approved JL1628 to make deviations as necessary for traffic. The traffic stayed with JL1628 through turns and decent in the vicinity of FAI I requested JL1628 to make a right 360° turn to see if he could identify the aircraft, he lost contact momentarily, at which time I observed a primary target in the 6 o'clock position 5 miles. I then vectored UA69 northbound to FAI from ANC with his approval to see if he could identify the aircraft, he had contact with the JL1628 flight but reported no other traffic, by this time JL1628 had lost contact with the traffic. Also a military C-130 southbound to EDF from EIL advised he had plenty of fuel and would take a look, I vectored him toward the flight and climbed him to FL240, he also had no contact.

Note: I requested JL1628 to identify the type or markings of the aircraft. He could not identify but reported white and yellow strobes. I requested the JL1628 to say flight conditions, he reported clear and no clouds.

Carl E. Henley

November 19, 1986

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PERSONNEL STATEMENT

FEDERAL AVIATION ADMINISTRATION
Anchorage Air Route Traffic Control Center

January 9, 1987

The following is a report concerning the incident involving aircraft JL1628 north of Fairbanks, Alaska on November 18, 1986 at 0218 UTC.

My name is Samuel J. Rich (SR). I am employed as an Air Traffic Control Specialist by the Federal Aviation Administration at the Anchorage Air Route Traffic Control Center, Anchorage, Alaska.

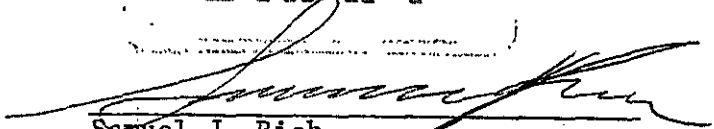
During the period of 0035 UTC, November 18, 1986, to 0835 UTC, November 18, 1986, I was on duty in the Anchorage ARTCC. I was working the D15 position from 0230 UTC, November 18, 1986, to 0530 UTC, November 18, 1986.

I returned from my break at approximately 0218 UTC to relieve Mr. Henley on the sector R/D15 position. In the process of relieving Mr. Henley I heard the pilot of JL1628 ask if we had any traffic near his position. I continued to monitor the position as Mr. Henley was too busy to give me a relief briefing. I monitored the situation for approximately twelve minutes at which time I assumed the D15 position and Mr. Henley moved to the R15 position. During the twelve minute period I heard the JL1628 pilot report the color of the lights were white and yellow. After the radar scale was reduced to approximately twenty miles I observed a radar return in the position the pilot had reported traffic.

After assuming the D15 position I called the ROCC at approximately 0230 UTC to ask if they had any military traffic operating near JL1628. The ROCC said they had no military traffic in the area. I then asked them if they could see any traffic near JL1628. ROCC advised that they had traffic near JL1628 in the same position we did.

I asked ROCC if they had any aircraft to scramble on JL1628, they said they would call back. I received no further communication regarding the request for a scramble.

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Samuel J. Rich
Air Traffic Control Specialist
Anchorage ARTCC

PERSONNEL STATEMENT

FEDERAL AVIATION ADMINISTRATION
Anchorage Air Route Traffic Control Center

January 9, 1986

The following is a report concerning the incident to Japan Airlines Flight 1628 (JL1628) North of Fairbanks, Alaska on November 18, 1986 at 0218 UTC.

My name is John L. Aarnink (AA). I am employed as an Air Traffic Control Specialist by the Federal Aviation Administration at the Anchorage Air Route Traffic Control Center (ARTCC), Anchorage, Alaska. During the period of 2230 UTC, November 17, 1986 to 0630 November 18, 1986 I was on duty in the Anchorage ARTCC. I was working the C15 position from approximately 0218 UTC, November 18, 1986 to 0250 UTC, November 18, 1986.

I was on my way to take a break when I noticed the unusual activity at the Sector 15 positions. I plugged into the C15 position and assisted them by answering telephone lines, making and taking handoffs and coordinating as necessary. As to the specific incident, I monitored the aircrafts transmissions and observed data on the radar that coincided with information that the pilot of JL1628 reported. I coordinated with the ROCC on the BRAVO and CHARLIE lines. They confirmed they also saw data in the same location. At approximately abeam CAVIN intersection, I no longer saw the data and the pilot advised he no longer saw the traffic. I called the ROCC and they advised they had lost the target. I then unplugged from the position and went on a break.


John L. Aarnink
Air Traffic Control Specialist.
Anchorage ARTCC

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